

Notes and Queries

[The editors will welcome as contributions to this section of *Western Folklore* small items of traditional materials and inquiries designed to elicit information about such materials. In general, discussion of the materials here offered will be brief. Records of facts likely to be lost or overlooked and inquiries which our readers may be able to answer will be the typical items.]

A New Circular Tale or Round.—In the notes and queries in *California Folklore Quarterly*, III (1944), 319, J. R. Caldwell printed a traditional round and called for other examples of the genre. Contributors have been generous in responding to the call; see *California Folklore Quarterly*, IV (1945), 85–86, 415; VI (1947), 86, 381–382; and *Western Folklore*, VIII (1949), 266. The following round seems, however, to have escaped notice.

One night I went to a bar and there I met a man. He said to me, “What have you been doing lately?”

And I said, “Last night I shot a man.”

“What was his name?” said he.

“Zanzibar,” said I.

“Zanzibar?” said he.

“Yes, Zanzibar,” said I.

“And how do you spell it?” said he.

“Z-a-n-z-i-b-a-r,” said I.

“Not Z-a-n-z-i-b-a-r!” said he.

“Yes, Z-a-n-z-i-b-a-r.”

“Then you shot my brother and I challenge you to a duel!” And I, being the challenged one, had my choice of weapons, so I chose my rusty trusty pistol. Three times I fired. He fell. The next night I went to a bar, and there I met a man, etc.

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The Lost Woman of San Nicolas Island.—Off the coast of California stands San Nicolas Island, once populated by a tribe of peaceful seagoing Indians. So peaceful, in fact, that history recounts it led to their downfall and ultimate virtual extinction years before American pioneers fought their way through other Indian tribes in order to reach California.

Because of constant raids by the Russian and Aleuts, these island Indians were rescued back in 1835 by the Spanish padres of the mainland missions and from this results the strange tale of the lost woman of San Nicolas.

When the rescue ship was about to sail, one of the women jumped overboard crying that her child had been left behind. Then, according to legend, a sudden storm drove the ship to sea before the woman could return to the

ship with her baby. The Indians aboard the ship were landed on San Pedro and taken to the Mission San Gabriel where they soon died.

It wasn't until 1853, some eighteen years later, that Padre Gonzales of the Santa Barbara Mission induced Captain George Nidever, an otter hunter, to attempt a trip to San Nicolas in order to find the lost woman. Captain Nidever made three trips to the wind-swept island, the last time taking a group of Barbareno Indians, who combed the island from one end to the other. After an arduous search a basket filled with feathers was uncovered. Searchers scattered the feathers but later found them all back in the basket and redoubled their efforts.

It was Captain Nidever who came upon the lost woman as she was skinning a seal in front of three small huts made of whale ribs. The woman showed no sign of being frightened and offered her visitor food. By signs she indicated her baby had been killed years before. She told her rescuer how she had existed on sea food and seals killed with crude stone weapons, she showed them well-hidden caves and canyons where she hid when marauding Russians and Aleuts visited the lonely isle on foraging expeditions.

Captain Nidever and his group returned with her to Santa Barbara where she created a great deal of excitement. It is reported that the Santa Barbara Mission where the woman was staying, turned down a fabulous offer for her to join a circus side show and tour the world.

Food on the mainland was new to her, however, and the shock to her system after forty-five years of existing on sea food and seal meat soon caused her death.

Her dress of bird skins, her trinkets including woven grass bottles and wooden knives were sent to the Vatican Museum in Rome, although history recounts some were destroyed in the great San Francisco fire of 1906.

Her death marked the passing of the last living Channel Island Indian. She was the sole survivor of a hardy race of peaceful seagoing Indians, who had known a "shangri-la" for hundreds of years.

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A Tall Tale About the Guano Trade.—The Chinchas are no South Sea isles of romance. These three tiny, miserable islands, lying fourteen miles off the coast of Peru, were the great American source of fertilizer during the mid-nineteenth century, however, and the guano trade which resulted placed heavy silver dollars in San Francisco and New York pockets.

This dirty business, dirty in more ways than one, was also responsible for the death spasm of slavery—blackbirding. Polynesians and Chinese were contracted or kidnapped and brought here to be worked to death or to com-